AI IN GOVERNMENT AND PUBLIC SERVICES - VOLUME 1

The AI Government Strategy Playbook

Where AI pays in citizen services, benefits, permitting, tax and emergency response, where public accountability, procurement rules and equity still govern, and how to phase AI into public services without breaking transparency, fairness, or audit.



Gates S0-S5 | 8 Templates | 20 Golden Rules

The worked example throughout is **Northbridge City and County**, a fictional composite government of 480,000 residents, 6,200 staff, and one shared service centre. Every figure attached to Northbridge is illustrative. Adapt the thresholds to your own statute, budget and risk appetite before you use them.

Executive / Service / Accountability lenses on every major section, so a cabinet member, a service owner and an auditor can read the same page and each find their decision.

START HERE

Government does not get to move fast and break things

A private firm that ships a bad model loses customers. A government that ships a bad model denies a benefit, misfiles a permit, or flags an innocent taxpayer - and the resident cannot take their business elsewhere. That asymmetry is the whole strategy. AI in government is adopted at the speed of trust, and trust is built with evidence, published in plain language, one service at a time.

How to use this playbook

- **Read pages 4-7 first.** They carry the thesis, the value test and the stop list. If a proposal fails there, nothing later in the book rescues it.
- **Work the gates in order.** S0 Mandate, S1 Portfolio, S2 Design, S3 Readiness, S4 Proof, S5 Scale. A gate is a decision with named evidence, not a stage a project drifts through.
- **Fill the templates as you go.** Templates 1-8 on pages 30-31 are the working record. A strategy that exists only in slides will not survive an audit, an election, or a change of administration.
- **Keep the lenses honest.** Executive, Service and Accountability callouts appear throughout. When the three lenses disagree, that disagreement is the decision - surface it, do not average it away.

The one-sentence strategy: automate the queue, the document and the lookup first; assist the caseworker second; and never automate the judgement a resident has a legal right to appeal.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund trust before capability. The first budget line is evaluation and transparency, not licences.

SERVICE LENS

Start where residents already wait: phones unanswered, forms returned, permits stalled.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every claim in this book must be producible later - to an auditor, a court, or a public records request.

THE SERIES

Ten volumes, one public-value discipline

This volume sets the strategy. The nine that follow go deep on each service line and on the shared foundations. Each volume is self-contained, uses the same gate pattern, and ends with eight templates and 20 golden rules.

Vol	Title	Core question
1	Strategy	Where does AI pay, and what must never be automated?
2	Citizen Services and Digital Front Doors	Can every resident reach help, in their language, on any channel?
3	Benefits, Licensing and Casework	Can AI speed a case without deciding it unfairly?
4	Permitting, Planning and Land Use	Can review get faster while the record stays defensible?
5	Tax, Revenue and Compliance	Can detection improve without treating residents as suspects?
6	Procurement and Supplier AI	What is the state buying, and can it leave?
7	Emergency Services and Public Safety	What may AI do when minutes and rights both matter?
8	Data, Records and Interoperability	Can agencies share data lawfully, once, with a record?
9	Workforce, Ethics and Public Trust	Who is accountable, and does the public believe it?
10	Government Capstone and Assurance	Does the whole portfolio hold up to independent assurance?

In this volume

The strategy in one page; where AI pays; where it does not	4-6
The public value test and Gate S0 - Mandate	7-8
Portfolio scoring, waves and Gate S1 - Portfolio	9-11
Operating model, decision rights, accountability and Gate S2 - Design	12-15
Data and records, interoperability, procurement, suppliers and Gate S3 - Readiness	16-20
Risk tiers, equity and due process, security and Gate S4 - Proof	21-24
Roadmap, workforce, measurement, economics and Gate S5 - Scale	25-29
Templates 1-8; the 20 Golden Rules	30-32

THE THESIS

The strategy in one page

Promise. Within three years, Northbridge residents get an answer on first contact for the ten highest-volume services, caseworkers spend their time on judgement instead of transcription, and every automated step in a public decision can be explained, logged and appealed.

Five strategic commitments

1. **Service outcomes, not model counts.** The portfolio is judged on wait time, error rate, completion rate and fairness gaps - never on how many AI tools were deployed.
2. **Assist before automate, automate before decide.** Copilots for staff first, automation of mechanical steps second, automated decisions last and rarely.
3. **One front door, every channel.** Web, phone, in person and paper all reach the same case record. Digital-only is a policy choice to exclude, and this strategy does not make it.
4. **Public by default.** A public register of AI systems, what they do, what data they use and how to appeal. Secrecy is reserved for genuine security and fraud-detection detail.
5. **Bought, not captured.** Open standards, exportable data, exit clauses and evaluation rights in every contract, so the state can change supplier without rebuilding the service.

> **Northbridge baseline (illustrative):** 1.1 million contacts a year, 38 percent about a case already open; average permit review 74 days; benefits error rate 6.1 percent, mostly missing documents, not fraud. The strategy attacks those three numbers first.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Say the promise in resident outcomes and put a date on it. Vague ambition cannot be audited.

SERVICE LENS

If a resident cannot tell what changed, the programme has not delivered, whatever the dashboard says.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish the baseline before you start. A baseline published afterwards is marketing.

WHERE AI PAYS

High volume, heavy documents, long queues

AI pays in government where the work is voluminous, repetitive and verifiable - where a correct answer exists, the evidence is in the file, and a human can check a sample and know whether the system is right.

Service area	What AI does	Why it pays
Contact centres	Retrieval over published guidance, call summarisation, translation	First-contact resolution rises; advice stays sourced to published text
Benefits intake	Document checks, missing-evidence prompts, form pre-fill	Most errors are missing documents; catching them at intake cuts rework and hardship
Permitting	Completeness checks, code lookup, review summaries	Reviewers start from a checked file instead of an incomplete one
Tax and revenue	Case prioritisation, correspondence drafting, anomaly triage	Officers work the highest-risk cases first; residents get clearer letters
Records and FOI	Search, redaction assistance, disclosure logs	Statutory deadlines met without burning out the records team
Emergency dispatch support	Call transcription, location and protocol prompts	Dispatchers keep judgement; the record writes itself
Internal operations	Meeting records, procurement drafting, HR policy lookup	Frees professional time across every department at low risk

The pattern is consistent: AI removes waiting, searching and re-typing. It does not remove the accountable officer, and in the paying use cases it does not need to.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Rank opportunities by resident pain multiplied by volume, not by vendor enthusiasm.

SERVICE LENS

Intake and triage are the safest high-value ground in the whole portfolio.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every paying use case produces its own evaluation data. If it cannot be checked, it does not pay - it merely runs.

THE STOP LIST

Where AI does not pay, and classical controls govern

Some government work must stay human, rule-based, or both - because the law requires a decision-maker, because the data encodes past injustice, or because the cost of a confident wrong answer falls on someone with no recourse.

Do not automate	Why	Use instead
Benefit eligibility decisions	Statutory discretion and appeal rights attach to a named decision-maker	AI prepares the file; an officer decides and signs
Enforcement selection from historical data	Past enforcement patterns encode where the state looked, not where harm is	Published risk criteria, human selection, disparate-impact testing
Child protection and safeguarding judgements	Consequences are irreversible and evidence is contested	Decision support only, with the social worker's judgement recorded as final
Political and policy choices	Democratic accountability cannot be delegated to a model	AI may summarise evidence; elected members decide
Sentencing, bail and parole inputs	Liberty interests; opaque scores cannot be cross-examined	Statutory frameworks and judicial judgement
Final fraud determinations	An accusation by algorithm denies due process in practice	AI triages; investigators establish facts; notices state evidence and appeal route

Rule of thumb: if a resident would be entitled to ask "who decided this, and on what evidence?" - a person must be able to answer, with the record in hand.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Hold the stop list publicly. It is the cheapest trust the programme will ever buy.

SERVICE LENS

A use case on the stop list is not a pilot opportunity. It is a closed door.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Review the list annually, in public, and record what was added or removed and why.

THE TEST

The public value test: five questions, all must pass

Every proposed use case answers five questions in writing before it enters the portfolio. One failure stops it until the failure is fixed or the proposal is withdrawn.

1. **Problem.** What resident or staff problem, measured today, does this solve? A baseline number is required - a wait, an error rate, a backlog, a cost per case.
2. **Legality.** What statute, regulation or policy authorises this use of data and this kind of decision support? Name it. "Innovation" is not a legal basis.
3. **Fairness.** Who could be made worse off, and how will you know? Name the groups, the test and the threshold that pauses deployment.
4. **Reversibility.** If the system is wrong at scale, how are affected residents found, notified and made whole? If there is no answer, there is no deployment.
5. **Value.** What does the whole thing cost over five years - licences, data work, evaluation, staff time, exit - against what measured benefit? Optimism is not a benefit.

> **Northbridge example:** benefits intake assistance passed all five - a measured 6.1 percent error rate, clear statutory basis for intake processing, fairness testing by language and disability status, full reversibility because officers still decide, and a five-year cost below the rework it removes. Automated eligibility scoring failed questions 2, 3 and 4 and was withdrawn at the test, before any vendor was engaged.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Apply the test before procurement. Afterwards, sunk cost argues louder than evidence.

SERVICE LENS

Make the answers public for anything resident-facing. Sunlight is a control.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A withdrawn proposal is the test working, not failing. Count withdrawals as a success metric.

GATE S0 - MANDATE

No mandate, no project

S0 Mandate: a named political sponsor, a named accountable officer, a legal basis and a funded evaluation line - or the work does not start.

Evidence required to pass

- A sponsor at cabinet or executive-board level who will defend the programme in public, including when a pilot is stopped.
- An accountable service owner, by name, whose performance objectives include the resident outcome - not the delivery date alone.
- A written legal review covering data use, decision rights, records retention and appeal routes.
- Funding that explicitly includes evaluation, accessibility, translation and the cost of the non-digital channels that must keep running.
- A communications commitment: the AI register entry is drafted before the build starts.

Automatic fail conditions

- The sponsor is a vendor, a consultancy, or "the innovation team" with no service owner attached.
- The business case counts staff savings from posts that no one has agreed to change.
- The timeline is set by an announcement date rather than by evidence milestones.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Your name is on this. If you would not defend it on the record, do not mandate it.

SERVICE LENS

A mandate that names an owner protects frontline staff when something goes wrong.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Auditors start at the mandate. A clean S0 record makes every later review shorter.

PORTFOLIO

Score the portfolio, not the pitch

Every candidate use case is scored on the same six factors, in the open, by a panel that includes the service owner, a data specialist, a frontline representative and an accountability reviewer. Scores and reasons are recorded in Template 2.

Factor	Weight	What earns a high score
Resident pain	25%	Long waits, high failure demand, hardship caused by delay or error
Volume and repeatability	15%	Thousands of similar cases with a stable, published rule set
Evidence readiness	20%	Clean case data, a checkable correct answer, an existing quality sample
Risk and reversibility	20%	Errors are detectable, correctable and compensable; no liberty or livelihood decision
Equity effect	10%	Narrows an access gap - language, disability, digital exclusion - rather than widening it
Deliverability	10%	One accountable owner, one system of record, no unresolved inter-agency dispute

Risk is scored inversely: the higher the harm if wrong, the lower the score, and any use case on the stop list (page 6) is excluded before scoring begins. A charismatic pitch cannot outscore a weak evidence base, because evidence readiness and risk together carry 40 percent of the weight.



Inside a Northbridge service centre: assisted digital help beside staffed counters, one case record across every channel.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Publish the scores. A portfolio that cannot be explained will not be defended.

SERVICE LENS

Score with the frontline in the room; they know where the failure demand hides.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Re-score annually. Yesterday's safe pilot is not automatically tomorrow's safe scale-up.

SEQUENCING

Three waves: prove, extend, connect

Wave 1 - Prove (months 0-12)

Internal and intake use cases with a human deciding everything: contact-centre retrieval and summarisation, benefits document checks, records search and redaction assistance, staff policy copilots. Goal: evaluation machinery that works, a public register that is real, and two or three services with published before-and-after numbers.

Wave 2 - Extend (months 12-24)

Resident-facing assistance with guardrails: guided applications, multilingual service guidance, permit completeness checks, appointment and queue optimisation. Goal: measurable equity gains - completion rates rising fastest for the groups previously worst served.

Wave 3 - Connect (months 24-36)

Cross-service work: tell-us-once data sharing with consent and a record, proactive entitlement prompts (a human confirms before any payment changes), joined-up case views for complex cases. Goal: residents stop being the integration layer between agencies.

> **Sequencing rule:** a wave starts when the previous wave's published results justify it, not when the calendar says so. Skipping Wave 1's evaluation discipline to reach Wave 3's ambition is how programmes end up in front of an inquiry.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Waves are evidence commitments. Tie funding release to published results.

SERVICE LENS

Wave 1 looks unglamorous and is where the programme is actually won.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Each wave's exit criteria belong in the public register, not an internal deck.

GATE S1 - PORTFOLIO

A balanced portfolio, or a smaller one

S1 Portfolio: every funded use case has passed the public value test, scored in the open, and fits inside the delivery and evaluation capacity that actually exists.

Evidence required to pass

- Public value test answers (Template 1) filed for every use case, including the ones rejected, with reasons.
- Scoring sheets (Template 2) signed by the full panel, dissent recorded rather than smoothed over.
- A capacity check: named evaluation, data and service-design staff matched to the portfolio size. Ten pilots with one evaluator is a plan to learn nothing ten times.
- A balance check: at least half the portfolio in Wave 1 risk territory for the first year.
- A kill list from last cycle: what was stopped, what it cost, what was learned - presented alongside the new asks.

Automatic fail conditions

- Any use case funded before scoring because a senior sponsor asked for it directly.
- Evaluation capacity below one named evaluator per three active pilots.
- No stopped work to report after a full year - a portfolio where nothing ever dies is not being managed.

EXECUTIVE LENS

A smaller portfolio that finishes beats a large one that announces.

SERVICE LENS

Capacity is the strategy. Fund people before platforms.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The kill list is your credibility with finance and with auditors alike.

OPERATING MODEL

Central standards, service ownership

Northbridge runs a hub-and-service model. A small central AI office owns standards, evaluation methods, the register and supplier frameworks. Service departments own their use cases, their data quality and their outcomes. Neither half works alone: central without services builds demos nobody adopts; services without central build ten incompatible tools and one shared incident.

Central AI office owns	Service departments own
AI policy, risk tiers and gate standards	The resident outcome and the service baseline
Evaluation methods, test sets and red-team practice	Case data quality and published guidance accuracy
The public AI register and transparency reporting	The accountable decision-maker for every case
Supplier frameworks, model inventory and exit tests	Frontline training, feedback and incident reporting
Shared platforms: retrieval, transcription, translation	Channel mix, including phone, paper and in-person

The central office stays small on purpose - Northbridge caps it at fourteen staff - because its product is standards and evidence, not delivery theatre. Delivery capacity sits in the services, close to the casework.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Keep the centre small and senior. Its authority comes from standards people actually use.

SERVICE LENS

Ownership follows the outcome: whoever owns the wait time owns the use case.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

One register, one risk framework, one evaluation method - or none of them will be believed.

DECISION RIGHTS

Who may decide what, in writing

Most AI failures in government are authority failures first: nobody was clearly empowered to stop the system, so nobody did. Decision rights are written down before deployment and tested in the first incident drill.

Decision	Decides	Must be consulted	Can stop the system
Approve a new use case	Service owner, through the gates	Legal, data protection, frontline lead	Accountability reviewer at gate review
Change a model or prompt in production	Service owner	Evaluation lead	Any officer who detects resident harm, pending review
Pause a live system	Duty manager, immediately	Service owner within 24 hours	Frontline staff, via the harm-report route
Publish results and incidents	Accountability officer	Service owner, communications	No one - publication is the default
Renew or exit a supplier	Procurement board	AI office, service owner	AI office, if exit or evaluation clauses are breached

> **The stop right matters most.** A frontline officer who sees a pattern of wrong outputs can raise a harm report that pauses the affected function pending review - without needing permission, and without career risk. Northbridge rehearses this twice a year, the way it rehearses fire drills.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Write the stop right into job descriptions and contracts, not just the policy PDF.

SERVICE LENS

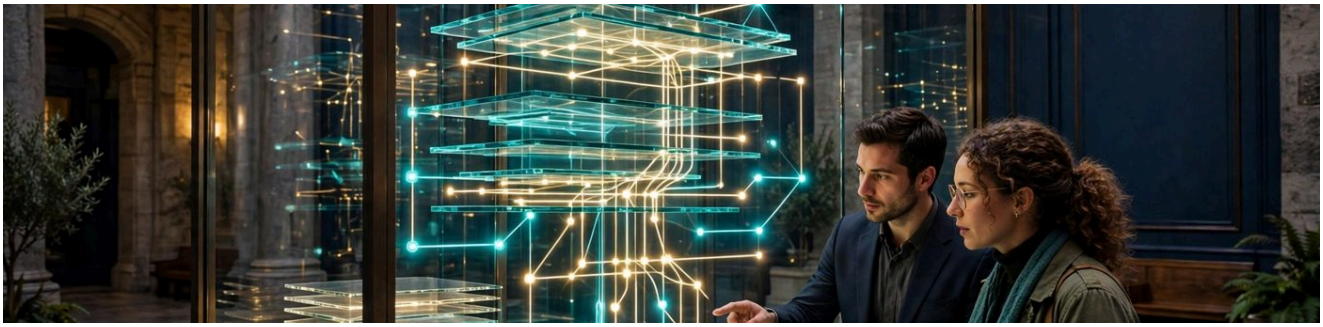
Ambiguity about authority is a decision too - it decides that the vendor's default wins.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Test decision rights in drills. Untested rights are decorative.

ACCOUNTABILITY

Transparency is a control, not a courtesy



The record as architecture: decision logs, evidence and appeal routes kept where auditors and residents can reach them.

Northbridge maintains a public AI register. Every live system has an entry a resident can read in five minutes: what it does, which service it supports, what data it uses, whether it influences a decision, who is accountable by name and role, how it is evaluated, and how to ask for a human review or appeal.

- **Decision logs.** For any AI-influenced case, the record shows what the system suggested, what evidence it used, and what the officer decided. Logs are records, retained under the same schedule as the case file.
- **Incident reporting.** AI incidents - wrong guidance at scale, biased outputs, data leakage - are logged, graded and summarised in a quarterly public report, including near misses.
- **Reasons on request.** A resident affected by an AI-influenced decision can get a plain-language explanation and a human re-decision. The explanation is written for the resident, not for the regulator.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Publish before you are asked. A register launched after a scandal is read as concealment.

SERVICE LENS

Name accountable roles publicly. Anonymous accountability is none.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Incident transparency compounds: each honest report makes the next one easier and cheaper.

GATE S2 - DESIGN

Designed for the resident who struggles most

S2 Design: the service design, data flow, human oversight point and appeal route are drawn, tested with residents, and costed end to end - before any build or buy decision.

Evidence required to pass

- A service blueprint showing every channel, including phone, paper and in-person, and where the human decides.
- User research with residents who have low digital access, limited English, or disabilities - not only confident online users.
- A data-flow map: what data, from where, under what legal basis, retained how long, visible to whom.
- An oversight design: sampling rates, review queues, and the exact point where a human can override - and how overrides are recorded.
- A whole-life cost (Template 4) including evaluation, translation, accessibility and exit.

Automatic fail conditions

- The design only works for residents who complete everything online, first time, in English.
- No named point of human decision in an AI-influenced case journey.
- The appeal route is "contact us" with no named process, owner or timescale.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Design for the hardest case first; the easy cases take care of themselves.

SERVICE LENS

If the appeal route is not designed, the service is not designed.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Cost the non-digital channels honestly. They are part of the service, not a legacy embarrassment.

FOUNDATIONS

Data and records: the unglamorous foundation

Every government AI programme discovers the same truth in month three: the model is fine and the data is the problem. Addresses in four formats, case notes as scanned handwriting, guidance pages contradicted by newer circulars. Strategy means funding the boring work first.

- **Guidance before generation.** Any system that answers residents retrieves from a single, owned, version-controlled guidance source. If two pages disagree, the fix is editorial, not technical - assign an owner to the truth.
- **Case data quality.** Measure completeness and accuracy of the fields a use case depends on, publish the figures internally, and set a minimum bar before pilot (Gate S3).
- **Records by design.** Prompts, outputs, model versions and officer decisions in AI-influenced cases are records. Retention, disclosure and legal-hold rules are agreed with the records team before launch, not after the first public records request arrives.
- **No shadow training data.** Resident data is not used to train or fine-tune any model - internal or vendor - without an explicit legal basis, a register entry and an opt-out where the law requires one.

> **Northbridge lesson:** the benefits intake pilot spent its first six weeks not on the model but on reconciling 214 guidance documents into 96 owned pages. Error rates fell before the AI switched on - a result the programme reported honestly, and which made its later AI claims believable.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund data cleaning as strategy, visibly. It is where the returns start.

SERVICE LENS

One owned source of guidance truth, or every channel invents its own.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Treat AI outputs as records from day one. Retrofitting retention is where programmes get hurt.

FOUNDATIONS

Interoperability and identity, without the mega-platform

Joined-up government does not require one giant system. It requires shared standards, lawful data sharing and a resident who only has to prove who they are and what happened once.

Layer	Standard Northbridge adopts	Guardrail
Identity	One resident sign-in, with assisted and in-person alternatives	No one is locked out of a statutory service for failing digital identity checks
Data sharing	Written agreements per purpose, logged access, tell-us-once for life events	Purpose limitation: shared for the stated service, not for general profiling
APIs and formats	Open standards, documented interfaces, exportable data	No supplier may hold case data in a format the state cannot read without them
Case view	A joined view for complex cases, assembled at point of need	Officers see what their role requires - not a universal resident dossier

The distinction in the last row matters. Interoperability serves the resident's case; a universal dossier serves the institution's curiosity. The strategy funds the first and forbids the second without explicit statutory authority.



One operations picture across permits, roadworks and service queues - shared situational awareness, not shared dossiers.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Standards before platforms. A standard outlives every vendor in the room.

SERVICE LENS

Tell-us-once is a resident right with a log attached, not a data grab.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Interoperability proposals get the same public value test as AI proposals.

PROCUREMENT

Buy outcomes and exit rights, not demos

Government buys AI badly when it buys the demo: a polished presentation on clean data, priced per seat, with the state's data as the switching cost. Northbridge procures against the service problem, on real (anonymised) case material, with the exit rehearsed at signing.

- **Evaluate on our data.** Shortlisted suppliers run the same held-out set of real cases. Scores are recorded and become contractual baselines.
- **Price the whole life.** Licences, integration, data preparation, evaluation, training, translation, and exit and migration - in one number, over the contract term (Template 4).
- **Contract for change.** Model versions, material changes and sub-processors are notified in advance; the state may re-test after any material change and suspend if performance falls below baseline.
- **Data terms.** State data is not used to train the supplier's general models. Ever. This clause is non-negotiable and its breach ends the contract.
- **Exit that works.** Data export in open formats, prompt and configuration escrow where relevant, and an annual exit test - an actual export, inspected, not a clause admired on paper.

EXECUTIVE LENS

The demo is the supplier's best day. Contract for their average day, measured on your cases.

SERVICE LENS

An untested exit clause is a hope, and hope is not leverage.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If a supplier will not accept evaluation rights, they are telling you what their product is worth.

GOVERNANCE

A model inventory the state actually controls

Every model in use - bought, built, or embedded inside another product - sits in one inventory with an owner, a version, an evaluation status and a review date. Embedded AI is the quiet risk: the case-management upgrade that quietly adds auto-summarisation, the office suite that adds drafting. Procurement and IT change processes must ask the AI question on every change, however small.

Register field	Why it matters
System, supplier, model and version	You cannot govern what you cannot name; version changes change behaviour
Use case, service owner, risk tier	Accountability attaches to a person and a tier, not to a product
Data used and legal basis	The first question in any audit, complaint or legal challenge
Evaluation baseline and last test date	Performance drifts; the date tells you whether anyone would know
Human oversight point and stop owner	The person who can pause it, reachable in an incident
Contract end and exit test date	Renewal should never arrive as a surprise with no alternative

Drift is normal; surprise is not. Re-test on every material model change and at least annually, and treat a supplier who resists re-testing as a risk finding in themselves.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Hunt the embedded AI. It enters through upgrades, not procurements.

SERVICE LENS

Version discipline is safety discipline in a world of silent model updates.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The inventory is a working tool reviewed monthly, not an annual compliance artefact.

GATE S3 - READINESS

Ready means measurable, staffed and reversible

S3 Readiness: baseline data captured, evaluation set built, staff trained, oversight staffed and a rollback rehearsed - before a single resident touches the system.

Evidence required to pass

- Baseline metrics locked and stored (Template 3): wait, error, completion, cost per case, and fairness breakdowns - measured before, never reconstructed after.
- An evaluation set of real, anonymised cases with agreed correct outcomes, held out from any supplier tuning.
- Accuracy and fairness thresholds set in advance, with the pause triggers written down (page 22).
- Frontline training completed and a staffed review queue, with named cover for absence.
- A rollback plan that has been executed once in rehearsal: how the service runs tomorrow if the system is switched off tonight.

Automatic fail conditions

- No baseline - "we will measure improvement later" is a fail, in those words if necessary.
- The evaluation set was built or seen by the supplier whose system it tests.
- Rollback depends on the supplier's cooperation to restore the previous process.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Readiness is mostly measurement. If you cannot prove it worked, assume it did not.

SERVICE LENS

Baselines locked before launch are the programme's pension - protect them.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Rehearse the rollback. The first execution should not be during the incident.

RISK

Four risk tiers, four levels of control

Controls scale with consequence. Northbridge tiers every use case at design and re-tiers it whenever its scope, data or decision role changes.

Tier	Description	Controls
T1 - Internal productivity	Staff drafting, summarisation, search; no resident impact	Standard guidance, spot checks, register entry
T2 - Resident information	Guidance, translation, status answers sourced to published text	Retrieval-only answers, source citation, sampling, feedback route on every answer
T3 - Case influence	Triage, prioritisation, document assessment that shapes an officer's work	Pre-set accuracy and fairness thresholds, human decision on every case, decision logs, quarterly public reporting
T4 - Decision-adjacent	Anything approaching eligibility, enforcement or liberty	Presumption against deployment; executive and legal sign-off, independent evaluation, published impact assessment - and the stop list still applies

Tier creep is the characteristic failure: a T2 guidance tool slowly starts ranking cases and becomes T3 without anyone re-approving it. The inventory review (page 19) compares what the system does now against the tier it was approved at, and treats silent expansion as an incident.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Tier the behaviour, not the intention. What it does decides.

SERVICE LENS

Re-tier on change, including the vendor's changes.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Treat tier creep as an incident, because unmanaged scope is how harm arrives quietly.

EQUITY

Equity and due process are launch criteria

A system that is accurate on average can still be unjust in distribution - worse for one language group, one disability, one neighbourhood. Northbridge therefore tests before launch and monitors after it, by the breakdowns that matter for each service.

- **Test by group.** Accuracy, completion and wait outcomes broken down by language, disability, age, channel and, where lawful and appropriate, ethnicity. Gaps beyond the pre-set threshold pause expansion, automatically.
- **Accessible by design.** Plain language at a tested reading level, screen-reader and assisted channels tested with disabled residents, human help reachable without a digital dead end.
- **Notice.** When AI influences a case, the resident is told - in the decision letter, in plain words, with the route to a human re-decision stated beside it.
- **Appeal that works.** Appeals go to a human with the full record, a named timescale, and outcomes tracked: if appeals against AI-influenced decisions succeed at a higher rate, that is a system finding, not a resident problem.

> **Northbridge example:** the multilingual guidance pilot improved overall completion by 11 points but only 2 points for one language group, because the translation handled formal phrasing and missed the colloquial terms residents actually used. Expansion paused, the language data was rebuilt with community reviewers, and the gap closed before scale. The pause was published in the quarterly report - and cited by residents' groups as a reason to trust the programme.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Average performance hides distributional harm. Always ask: for whom is it worse?

SERVICE LENS

A pause for equity, published honestly, builds more trust than a flawless launch claim.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Appeal outcomes are evaluation data. Mine them.

SECURITY

Security, privacy and fraud: assume a motivated reader

Public services hold data residents were compelled to give. That raises the bar: the state did not earn this data in a market transaction, and residents cannot withdraw it. Security and privacy design starts from that obligation.

- **Data minimisation in prompts.** Systems receive the fields the task needs, not the whole case file. Prompt and retrieval logs are reviewed for accidental exposure of personal data.
- **Prompt injection and leakage.** Resident-facing retrieval is tested against attempts to extract other residents' data, internal instructions and restricted guidance. Red-team results are part of Gate S4 evidence.
- **Fraud, honestly balanced.** AI-assisted fraud detection runs under the same due-process rules as any triage: it prioritises human investigation, it never itself determines fraud, and false-positive rates are monitored by group, because a false accusation by the state is a serious harm.
- **Supplier security.** Data residency, sub-processor lists, breach notification within a contracted window, and the state's right to audit - verified, not attested.
- **Incident readiness.** A named playbook for AI incidents that joins the existing security and communications plans, with pre-agreed public wording for the common cases.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Compelled data, higher duty. Design as if every log will one day be read aloud.

SERVICE LENS

Test leakage before launch; residents will test it after.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Fraud savings claims must be net of false-positive harm, or they are fiction.

GATE S4 - PROOF

Pilots that are allowed to fail

S4 Proof: a time-boxed pilot against the locked baseline, with pre-registered success and stop criteria, independently evaluated - and a real possibility of a no.

Evidence required to pass

- Pre-registered criteria (Template 5): the metrics, thresholds, fairness breakdowns and duration, filed before the pilot starts and not edited afterwards except by a logged amendment.
- Independent evaluation - by the central office or an external evaluator, never by the supplier or the delivery team marking its own work.
- Resident and staff feedback gathered deliberately, including from people who abandoned the service mid-journey.
- Full cost accounting for the pilot, including staff time and evaluation, so scale economics are real.
- A stop, fix or scale recommendation with the evidence attached, decided at a gate review the sponsor attends.

Automatic fail conditions

- Success criteria written or revised after results were seen.
- Pilot users cherry-picked from the easiest cases or the most digital residents.
- A pilot with no end date. Permanent pilots are unaccountable deployments wearing a lanyard.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Protect the pilot's right to fail; a pilot that cannot fail teaches nothing.

SERVICE LENS

Independent evaluation is what separates a programme from a sales channel.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish pilot results either way. The no results are the ones the public remembers you sharing.

ROADMAP

The 36-month roadmap, tied to evidence

Period	Deliver	Evidence that unlocks the next step
Months 0-6	Register live, baselines locked, guidance consolidated, first two Wave 1 pilots running	S0-S3 gate records complete and published in summary
Months 6-12	Wave 1 results published, supplier framework retendered on evaluation terms, staff copilot rollout	At least two pilots pass S4 with equity breakdowns reported
Year 2	Wave 2 resident-facing assistance in three services, multilingual front door, permit completeness checks	Wave 1 services holding gains at scale; no unresolved fairness pauses
Year 3	Wave 3 tell-us-once for two life events, proactive entitlement prompts with human confirmation	Independent assurance review (Volume 10 method) with findings published

Dates are planning aids; the evidence column is the commitment. If the evidence is not there, the roadmap slips and the slip is announced with the reason - a habit that costs a headline once and buys credibility for years.

> **What is deliberately not on the roadmap:** automated eligibility decisions, predictive enforcement targeting, and any resident scoring. Naming the exclusions on the roadmap page itself prevents their quiet return in someone else's plan.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Publish the roadmap with its evidence conditions attached.

SERVICE LENS

Announce slips with reasons. Silence converts a delay into a scandal.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Keep the exclusions printed on the roadmap, where future planners will see them.

WORKFORCE

The workforce is the delivery mechanism

AI in government succeeds or fails at the caseworker's desk. Staff who fear the programme will route around it, and their workarounds will be invisible to the dashboards. Northbridge treats workforce change as a first-class workstream, not a communications task.

- **No-surprises commitment.** A published commitment on how roles change: AI absorbs transcription, search and drafting first; role changes are negotiated, trained for, and never announced by press release before they are discussed with staff and unions.
- **Skills, in work time.** Every affected role gets role-specific training - prompting, verification, override judgement, record-keeping - delivered in working hours with backfill, not as homework.
- **Professional judgement protected.** Guidance states plainly: the officer's judgement prevails over the system, overrides are recorded without penalty, and a pattern of overrides is treated as system feedback.
- **New roles, honestly counted.** Evaluation, data stewardship, AI oversight and community language review are real new jobs. The strategy counts them in the economics instead of pretending the programme is costless to run.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Negotiate role change early. Surprised workforces do not adopt, they endure.

SERVICE LENS

Training in work time, with backfill - or it is a poster, not a programme.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Overrides are data and professional rights at once. Protect both.

MEASUREMENT

Measure what residents feel

The measurement framework (Template 6) has four families, reported quarterly, in public, with the same definitions every time.

Family	Measures	Why
Outcomes	Wait to resolution, first-contact resolution, error and rework rates, backlog age	What residents actually experience, end to end
Equity	Completion, wait and accuracy gaps by language, disability, age and channel	Whether the service is fairer, not just faster
Trust	Appeal rates and success rates, complaint themes, resident survey confidence, register readership	Whether the public believes the system is on their side
Economics	Cost per resolved case, whole-life cost against the business case, evaluation cost as a share of programme cost	Whether the money story told at S0 is still true

Two disciplines keep the numbers honest. Definitions are versioned and changes are footnoted in the report where they first appear. And every favourable headline metric is published beside its equity breakdown, so good averages cannot smuggle in bad distributions.

Report the misses on the same page as the hits. A quarterly report that residents and journalists learn to trust is worth more than any single result in it.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Four families or the story tilts - usually toward cost, away from fairness.

SERVICE LENS

Stable definitions are a integrity asset. Guard them.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Trust metrics are leading indicators; by the time outcomes fall, belief went first.

ECONOMICS

Economics: honest money, five-year view

Government AI business cases fail in predictable places: licences counted, integration forgotten; savings booked from posts that still exist; evaluation treated as optional overhead. Northbridge costs every use case whole-life (Template 4) and re-forecasts at every gate.

Cost line	Commonly forgotten element
Licences and usage	Usage-based pricing grows with success - model the scaled volume, not the pilot volume
Data and integration	Guidance consolidation, case-data cleaning, API work - often the largest real cost
People	Training time with backfill, review queues, evaluation and oversight roles
Assurance	Independent evaluation, red-teaming, accessibility and language testing
Channels	Phone, paper and in-person services continue - savings cannot assume they vanish
Exit	Migration, data export and parallel running at contract end

Benefits are claimed conservatively and in kind: time returned to casework (counted as capacity, not cash, unless posts genuinely change), error and rework avoided, hardship reduced by faster correct decisions. Cash savings are claimed only when a budget line actually falls.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Model the scaled price on day one. Pilot pricing is a vendor's investment, not your forecast.

SERVICE LENS

Capacity returned is a real benefit; call it that, not a saving.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If evaluation looks expensive, price the alternative: one public failure.

GATE S5 - SCALE

Scale is a new decision, not a bigger pilot

S5 Scale: pilot evidence at production volumes, unit economics confirmed, oversight staffed for scale, and a dated review - or the system stays at pilot size.

Evidence required to pass

- S4 results meeting the pre-registered thresholds, including equity breakdowns, sustained for the full pilot - not a good month selected from it.
- Load and failure testing at production volume, with the rollback rehearsed again at the new scale.
- Whole-life economics re-forecast with real pilot costs, and funding for ongoing evaluation - typically 10-15 percent of run cost, protected in the budget.
- Oversight scaled with volume: review sampling, appeal handling and incident capacity all grow with case numbers, by formula agreed at this gate.
- A sunset and review date in the register: every scaled system is re-evaluated against current standards within three years.

Automatic fail conditions

- Scaling because the contract, announcement or budget cycle requires it, ahead of evidence.
- Evaluation funding treated as a one-off project cost that ends at go-live.
- No review date. A system with no scheduled re-examination is a system designed to drift.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Scale on evidence, announce afterwards - in that order, every time.

SERVICE LENS

Protect the evaluation share of run cost as fiercely as the licence budget.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Sunset dates keep today's good system from becoming tomorrow's legacy problem.

TEMPLATES 1-4

Fill these in: the strategy as a working record

Template 1 - Public Value Test

Field	Your entry
Problem and today's baseline number	
Legal basis (statute / regulation / policy)	
Who could be worse off, and the fairness test and threshold	
Reversibility: how affected residents are found, notified, made whole	
Five-year whole-life cost vs measured benefit	
Decision: proceed / fix / withdraw, with name and date	

Template 2 - Portfolio Score Sheet

Field	Your entry
Use case and service owner	
Resident pain (25%) and volume (15%) scores, with evidence	
Evidence readiness (20%) and risk / reversibility (20%) scores	
Equity effect (10%) and deliverability (10%) scores	
Panel members, dissent recorded, total and rank	

Template 3 - Baseline Lock

Field	Your entry
Service and metric definitions (versioned)	
Wait, error, completion and cost-per-case baseline values	
Equity breakdowns captured	
Data source, measurement date and owner	
Signed and stored before pilot - date and location	

Template 4 - Whole-Life Cost

Field	Your entry
Licences and usage at scaled volume	
Data, guidance and integration work	
Training, review queues, evaluation and oversight roles	
Accessibility, translation and non-digital channel costs	
Exit, migration and parallel-running costs	
Five-year total vs business-case figure	

Copy each template into your programme record. Blank fields are findings: a template that cannot be filled in is telling you the work is not ready for its gate.

TEMPLATES 5-8

Fill these in: proof, measurement, incidents, suppliers

Template 5 - Pilot Pre-Registration

Field	Your entry
Hypothesis and the decision this pilot informs	
Success thresholds and stop criteria, set in advance	
Metrics and equity breakdowns to be reported	
Duration and end date; pilot population and how chosen	
Independent evaluator, named	
Amendment log (dated, reasoned, approved)	

Template 6 - Quarterly Measurement Report

Field	Your entry
Outcomes: wait, first-contact resolution, error, backlog age	
Equity gaps by language, disability, age and channel	
Trust: appeals, appeal success rate, complaint themes	
Economics: cost per resolved case vs business case	
Misses reported beside hits; definition changes footnoted	

Template 7 - AI Incident Record

Field	Your entry
What happened, when detected, how detected	
Residents affected and how identified	
Immediate action: paused / fixed / rolled back, by whom	
Notification: residents, regulator, public summary	
Root cause and the change that prevents recurrence	

Template 8 - Supplier Exit Test

Field	Your entry
Data export completed in open formats - date and result	
Prompts, configurations and documentation recovered	
Evaluation baseline reproducible without the supplier	
Parallel-running plan and cost	
Gaps found and remediation dates	

Templates 5 and 8 are the two most skipped and the two that matter most: one protects the truth of your results, the other protects your freedom to change your mind.

Rules to keep when everything else is under pressure

1. Automate the queue, the document and the lookup before anything that resembles a decision.
2. A named person decides every case a resident can appeal.
3. No baseline, no pilot. No exceptions, whatever the announcement calendar says.
4. Publish the register entry before the system, not after the story breaks.
5. Score the portfolio in the open and keep the rejected cases on file.
6. Fund evaluation like you mean it: named people, protected budget, independent voice.
7. Design for the resident with the least access first; everyone else is already served.
8. Tell residents when AI touched their case, in the letter, in plain words.
9. Make the appeal easier than the original application.
10. Never train on compelled data without a legal basis and a public entry.
11. Buy exit rights and test them annually; an untested exit is a hope.
12. Tier the behaviour, re-tier on change, and treat silent expansion as an incident.
13. Report equity beside every average. Averages are where unfairness hides.
14. Let any frontline officer pause the system for harm, without permission or penalty.
15. Pilots end: with evidence, a decision and a published result - pass or fail.
16. Count returned time as capacity, not cash, until a budget line actually falls.
17. Keep phone, paper and in-person channels funded as part of the service.
18. Suppliers get evaluated on your real cases, before and after they are paid.
19. Review every scaled system within three years against the standards of that day.
20. When in doubt, choose the option you could defend in public, on the record, to the resident affected.

Volume 1 assurance checklist

- Public value test applied to every funded use case, withdrawals recorded.
- Gates S0-S5 evidenced, with fail conditions enforced at least once visibly.
- Register live and current; incident summaries published quarterly.
- Stop list (page 6) reviewed within the last 12 months.
- Templates 1-8 in active use in the programme record.
- Next review date for this strategy: set, owned and in the register.

The series continues

Volume 2, Citizen Services and Digital Front Doors, takes the front door apart channel by channel: what a resident experiences on web, phone, paper and in person, and how one case record serves them all.

Northbridge City and County is a fictional composite created for this series. Any resemblance to a real government is a sign the problems are common, not that the figures are real.